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[< Previous Topic](#)[Next Topic >](#)

## G2. Categories

While there is no definitive directory of *grandes écoles* – in fact, the term does not generally appear in the relevant French legislation or other official documents that codify the French system – there are some conventionally agreed categories or groupings that make it easier to understand this important pathway in French higher education. These can be broadly framed as follows.

### ***Écoles normales supérieures (ENS)***

There are four such institutions currently, including the *École normale supérieure (Paris)* which is one of the country's most prestigious and selective institutions. ENS Paris is a member-institution of the *Université Paris Sciences et Lettres*, one of top-ranked French institutions in global university tables. It accepts just 200 new students each year through what can only be described as a highly competitive process. The *écoles normales supérieures* emphasise studies in the sciences and humanities and are an important training ground for French scholars and civil servants.

### ***Grandes écoles d'ingénieurs***

The term “engineer” is very broadly defined within the French system and can be used to refer to conventional engineering disciplines and qualifications as well as to someone who has achieved an advanced level of more generalised study in a variety of fields, including science, the humanities and business administration.

There are somewhere between 150 and 200 *grandes écoles d'ingénieurs*, many of which are affiliated in regional or national groups of institutions. These include:

- the *écoles nationales supérieures d'ingénieurs* (ENSI), a network of 40 advanced engineering schools throughout France;
- the *Réseau Polytech*, a group of 13 schools where each is in turn affiliated with a French university; and
- the ParisTech group, which includes specialised institutes of aerospace and defense technology, agriculture and telecommunications. Also included in this latter group is the famous *École Polytechnique* (EP). Commonly known simply by the nickname "l'X", the EP is one of the top-rated French institutions and also one of the most highly regarded engineering schools in the world.

Also included among the *grandes écoles d'ingénieurs* are the three *universités de technologie* (UT): the *Université de technologie de Belfort-Montbéliard* (UTBM), *Université de technologie de Compiègne* (UTC) and the *Université de technologie de Troyes* (UTT). This is a distinct sub-category of institution which combines the selectivity and elite status of the *grandes écoles* with the research and technology transfer responsibilities of the universities.

## ***Grandes écoles de commerce***

Alongside the country's leading engineering schools is the other major category of *grandes écoles de commerce*. These elite business schools are mainly private institutions, in some cases operated by regional chambers of commerce in France. Unofficial counts suggest that there as many as 200 *grandes écoles* for business studies, including the world-famous *Institut européen d'administration des affaires* (more commonly known as "INSEAD"), France's leading graduate school of business and the home of the one of the most highly regarded MBA programmes in the world.

## ***Other types of grandes écoles***

Outside of these major categories, there are also a number of *grandes écoles* dedicated to studies in political science and public administration. These include:

- the *instituts d'études politiques* (IEP), a group of ten public, political science-focused institutions throughout the country; and
- the *Institut d'études politiques de Paris*, a Paris-based institution that is commonly referred to as "Sciences Po" and which has expanded in

recent years to include campuses in six other French cities.

Other specialist schools exist for advanced studies in journalism studies, art, architecture and social sciences.

Finally, there are three military academies that are also classified as *grandes écoles*: the *École spéciale militaire de Saint-Cyr* (army), the *École de l'air* (air force) and the *École navale* (navy).

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[< Previous Topic](#)

[Back to Lesson](#)

[Next Topic >](#)